Systematic Literature Review (Draft)

Pricing the Unpriced: Heritage-Anchored Highest and Best Use on Greenmount Avenue, Baltimore

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1. Introduction and Review Questions

Greenmount Avenue between East 29th and East 35th Streets is the spine of the Waverly Main Street Historic District, listed on the National Register of Historic Places in 2013. It was once a busy neighborhood main street. Today, by one press count, more than one in four of its buildings appear completely empty (Gellman & Jayaraman, 2026). Our capstone sponsor holds an unusually deep record of what each address on this street was used for, in some cases going back to the nineteenth century. The project asks whether that history can guide what each building should become, and whether the resulting mix of uses would work commercially as a neighborhood. We call this *heritage-anchored highest and best use*.

Conventional highest-and-best-use analysis starts from zoning, building size and market rent. Our approach adds a building's documented past uses as a prior for its future use. This draws on several literatures that rarely meet: the economics of historic preservation, retail location and agglomeration, and the study of vacancy and revitalization in disinvested cities. The review is organized around four questions:

1. **RQ1 (heritage and value).** How do built heritage and historic designation affect property values, inside and around historic buildings and districts, and through what mechanisms?
2. **RQ2 (trade areas and tenant mix).** What determines whether a commercial street can support a given use? What does the literature say about trade areas, retail agglomeration, tenant mix and saturation?
3. **RQ3 (vacancy, revitalization and viability).** What does the evidence say about the costs of vacancy and the effects of revitalization programs in disinvested corridors, particularly in Baltimore?
4. **RQ4 (precedent case).** What happened the last times government tried to plan what Greenmount should hold, and what does that suggest for our recommendations?

2. Methods

2.1 Sources

We combined four routes into the literature:

1. **The sponsor's reading list.** The sponsor's annotated reading list (October 7, 2026) names 25 distinct works or document sets for this project, plus a separate list for the deferred tenant-to-owner idea, which is excluded here. Copies of seven of these entries are in the sponsor's reading repository.

2. **A structured database search.** On October 21, 2026 we ran five Boolean searches in OpenAlex, an open bibliographic index of scholarly works, over titles and abstracts. Filters were publication from 1990, English language, and articles, reviews, book chapters or preprints (Table 1).
3. **Citation chasing.** We followed backward citations from Been et al. (2016) and Manganelli et al. (2023), and ran targeted title searches for well-known retail-economics studies cited in the screened papers.
4. **Primary and local sources.** We used the National Register nominations for the district and two neighboring resources, the team's index of the City's 1970s Waverly revitalization files, and recent local reporting.

2.2 Screening and inclusion

For each search we screened the 40 most relevant records by title (200 records in all), then read abstracts for those that passed. We included a study if it met all four criteria:

1. It is empirical or theoretical work on property values, retail viability, tenant mix, or vacancy and revitalization in urban commercial or mixed-use areas.
2. It is peer-reviewed, or a report by a recognized research institution or public body.
3. It bears on at least one review question.
4. It has a usable abstract or full text.

We excluded studies of building conservation technique, perception-only marketing studies of shopping centers, non-urban settings, and sources whose findings we could not verify. Primary sources (nominations, archival files) and press reporting are used as context, not as evidence of effects.

Table 1. Database search log (OpenAlex, title and abstract, 1990 onward, run October 21, 2026)

#	Search string	Hits	Titles screened	Included (new)
Q1	("historic district" OR "historic designation" OR "historic preservation" OR "built heritage") AND ("property value(s)" OR "house prices" OR "housing prices")	93	40	6
Q2	"tenant mix" OR "retail mix" OR "retail agglomeration" OR "store mix" OR "retail clustering"	606	40	3
Q3	("commercial corridor" OR "main street" OR "neighborhood retail" OR "commercial district") AND (revitalization OR vacancy OR "vacant storefront")	304	40	1
Q4	("adaptive reuse" OR "building reuse" OR "historic rehabilitation") AND (commercial OR retail OR economic OR value)	1,528	40	1
Q5	("vacant" OR "abandoned" OR "blighted") AND ("property values" OR "spillover" OR "house prices") AND (neighborhood OR nearby)	143	40	2
Total, plus 8 sources from citation chasing and 25 from the sponsor list		**2,674**	**200**	**13 + 8 + 25 = 46**

Many screened records duplicated studies already on the sponsor list (for example Coulson & Leichenko, 2001; McCabe & Ellen, 2016; Patrick, 2025). Those are counted under the sponsor list, not as new.

2.3 Limitations of the search

This draft has four main limitations:

- **One database, one screener.** We searched only OpenAlex, and one screener did the screening.
- **Thin abstracts.** OpenAlex's abstract coverage is incomplete, which may explain the low hit count for Q1.
- **Partial reading.** Several paywalled studies were read only through their abstracts or through summaries in the review by Manganelli et al. (2023). Appendix A records the depth at which each source was read, and figures taken only from the sponsor's annotated reading list are marked *[annotation]* in the text.
- **Effects not directly comparable.** Effect sizes are reported in the units the studies use, which differ (Section 7).

3. Heritage, Designation and Property Value (RQ1)

3.1 How the literature frames the question

Most studies in this literature use hedonic price models, which treat a property's price as the sum of implicit prices for its attributes (Rosen, 1974). Heritage enters as one more attribute: a designation, an age or style variable, or distance to listed buildings.

The theory points in two directions at once. On one side, designation preserves an amenity, signals prestige, reduces uncertainty about what neighbors may build, and can unlock tax incentives. On the other, it restricts alterations and forecloses redevelopment, which destroys option value where land is valuable (Been et al., 2016; Manganelli et al., 2023). Been et al. turn this into a testable prediction. Designation should raise values where the forgone development option is worth little: in lower-demand areas, or where buildings already reach their zoning limits. It should matter less, or even reduce values, where demand is high and buildings sit far below what zoning allows.

3.2 Effects on designated properties ("internal" effects)

Most studies find a premium for designated properties, but the range is wide. Manganelli et al.'s (2023) thirty-year review tabulates estimates for individually designated properties. These include 17.6% in Abilene, Texas (Coulson & Leichenko, 2001), 5–20% across nine Texas cities (Leichenko et al., 2001), and 16% for Mills Act properties in San Diego (Narwold et al., 2008). They also include a 24% *discount* for small apartment buildings in Philadelphia (Asabere et al., 1994), which the review attributes to maintenance costs and limits on alteration. For districts, Coulson and Lahr (2005) find faster appreciation in designated Memphis neighborhoods than in comparable undesignated ones, and the gain extends to newer buildings inside the districts. In Denver, Zhou (2020) estimates a 12–23% post-designation premium.

The strongest designs qualify these results. Been et al. (2016) use New York City sales from 1974 to 2009 and the staggered timing of the city's 120 historic district designations. Citywide, the working-

paper estimates of the designation effect are roughly 9.5% over the ten years after designation and 14.8% over the full period. These estimates weaken once area-specific time trends are controlled. The gains are concentrated outside Manhattan. In Manhattan, where the development option is most valuable, designation brings no greater gains than in comparable surroundings. In Chicago, Noonan and Krupka (2011) model which properties get designated and control for historic quality, which the market values. Once they do, the regulatory restriction itself has negative price effects on average. In Berlin, listed landmarks sell at neither a premium nor a discount (Ahlfeldt & Maennig, 2010). And in Atlanta, Patrick (2025) is reported to find a premium of about 13–14% for National Register listing, which bundles the federal tax credit, while local designation trends toward zero *[annotation]*.

3.3 Effects on neighbors ("external" effects)

The evidence for positive spillovers to nearby properties is more consistent than the evidence on the designated properties themselves.

- **Berlin.** Proximity to landmarks raises condominium prices within about 600 meters (Ahlfeldt & Maennig, 2010).
- **New York City.** Properties just outside new districts sell for less than comparable properties before designation and gain after it, by 11.9% in one specification (Been et al., 2016).
- **Denver.** Neighboring homes show a 10–20% spillover (Zhou, 2020).
- **The Netherlands.** An increase of one million euros per square kilometer in subsidised investment in cultural heritage raises the prices of non-targeted homes by 1.5–3.0% (Koster & Rouwendal, 2017).

This matters for Greenmount. The restriction burden falls on the designated building, but the amenity can benefit the block around it.

3.4 Heterogeneity, welfare and who benefits

Three findings caution against simply transferring a headline premium to Waverly.

- **The regime matters.** Oba and Noonan (2020) find large differences in effects between national and local districts, between interior and buffer properties, and across the price distribution. National Register listing by itself does not restrict private owners the way New York's local landmark law does, although Waverly's urban renewal plan sets its own design rules (Section 6). Most of the best-identified evidence, however, comes from local landmark regimes.
- **Price is not welfare.** For English conservation areas, Waights (2018) finds that designation raises quality of life but lowers housing productivity, with a negative net welfare effect. Ahlfeldt et al. (2017) find that new designations at the margin are not capitalized into prices, consistent with designation tracking homeowner preferences.
- **Distribution.** In New York City, designation was followed by a significant rise in neighborhood socioeconomic status but little change in racial composition (McCabe & Ellen, 2016). Manganelli et al. (2023) likewise flag gentrification and displacement of small businesses as a cost. Steinberg (2011) shows how contested landmark decisions are, and argues for a clearer process to undo designations that no longer serve their purpose.

3.5 What this means for the project

Heritage carries economic value, but the size and even the sign of the effect depend on the regime, the market and the building type. Almost all the evidence concerns residential sales. We found no study that estimates how a building's *former commercial use*, as opposed to its designation or age, affects its value or the success of a new tenant. This is the gap our project sits in. It means our "heritage anchor" has to be justified as a plausible prior and tested against demand, rather than borrowed from an established effect size.

4. Trade Areas, Agglomeration and Tenant Mix (RQ2)

4.1 Trade areas and shopping trips

Huff (1964) defined a store's trading area probabilistically. The likelihood that a consumer visits a store rises with the store's attractiveness and falls with travel time, relative to all competing stores. This logic still underlies market-area analysis and is directly usable for Greenmount, whose stores compete with a large supermarket next door and with other shopping destinations nearby.

Agglomeration adds to the simple gravity logic. In a nested-logit model estimated on 1,704 Dutch households, Arentze et al. (2005) show that the numbers and types of stores at a destination attract not only multi-purpose trips but single-purpose ones too. Models that ignore this understate the benefit of clustering.

4.2 Inter-store externalities and tenant mix

Shopping-center economics treats tenants as generating traffic for one another. Brueckner (1993) models how a developer allocates space to internalize these inter-store externalities. Empirically, anchor department stores receive rent subsidies of at least 72% relative to what other mall tenants pay per square foot, because they generate traffic that smaller stores free-ride on (Pashigian & Gould, 1998). Tenant type is also a significant determinant of base rents (Gerbich, 1998, using 293 New Zealand leases).

The key difference on a high street is that ownership is fragmented, so no single landlord internalizes these effects. Two Dutch studies speak directly to this setting:

- **Footfall.** Koster, Pasidis and van Ommeren (2019) estimate an elasticity of store owners' rental income with respect to pedestrian footfall of 0.25. They show that subsidizing shops that generate high footfall, by about 10% of rent on average, would raise welfare.
- **Tenant mix.** Song, van Duijn and van der Vlist (2023) find that high-street shopping districts with a more diverse tenant mix command higher retail rents.

Jacobs (1961) made the planning version of this argument. Street vitality depends on a mix of primary uses that bring people at different hours. Jacobs also argued that a district needs a stock of older buildings, because new and marginal enterprises cannot afford the rents of new construction. That point bears directly on heritage-anchored reuse.

4.3 Neighborhood retail composition and stability

Retail supply is uneven across neighborhoods. In New York City, lower-income and minority neighborhoods have fewer and smaller retail establishments and a higher share of "unhealthy" restaurants, and in some cases less diversity across retail subsectors. Retail growth between 1998 and 2007 was fastest in initially lower-valued neighborhoods that saw rapid price appreciation (Meltzer & Schuetz, 2012). Turnover follows similar lines. Consumer characteristics explain retail churn better than the commercial environment does, businesses selling necessities are more stable, and population growth predicts more turnover (Meltzer & Capperis, 2017).

4.4 What this means for the project

The literature supports treating Greenmount as a coordination problem. The value of each use depends on the mix around it, and fragmented ownership means no one internalizes that. It also gives us measurable inputs for "saturation": footfall, the diversity of the tenant mix, and the distance to competing uses in a Huff-type market area. The literature does not define saturation for small neighborhood corridors. The sponsor's rule of thumb ("six bodegas in a row fail; one every two blocks can work") is consistent with it, but untested. Our tenant-mix module should therefore state its saturation rule explicitly and test how sensitive results are to it. The weekly 32nd Street Farmers Market and established destinations such as Red Emma's can be treated as traffic anchors in the sense of Pashigian and Gould (1998).

5. Vacancy, Revitalization and Commercial Viability (RQ3)

5.1 The cost of vacancy in Baltimore

Baltimore has the best local evidence on residential vacancy:

- **Repeat sales, 1991–2010.** Each additional abandoned property within 250 feet lowers a home's price by about 0.9% *[annotation]*. The effect grows, and reaches farther, the longer properties stay abandoned (Han, 2014).
- **Threshold effects.** The marginal damage rises sharply once more than two abandoned properties lie within 250 feet, and falls again beyond about fourteen (Han, 2019).
- **City-wide cost.** Miller and McComas (2022) estimate that vacant housing costs Baltimore on the order of $200 million a year in lost tax revenue, lost nearby value and direct services, with costs falling mainly on majority-Black neighborhoods.
- **Vacants to Value.** An evaluation of the City's program reports that assessed values fell 1.7% for occupied properties, 12.2% for vacant ones and 34.8% for demolished ones between 2009 and 2014 (BNIA-JFI, 2016) *[annotation]*.

Brown (2021) supplies the frame for all of this: Baltimore's vacancy is the product of a racialized geography of investment.

5.2 What interventions do

Revitalization produces measurable but local and conditional gains:

- **Richmond, Virginia.** Concentrated revitalization raised land prices 2–5% a year faster than in a control area. The externality halves roughly every 1,000 feet, and each program dollar yielded $2–6 in land value (Rossi-Hansberg et al., 2010).
- **Rehabilitating a neighbor.** This is reported to raise nearby prices by about 2.3 percentage points per rehab (Ganduri & Maturana, 2024) *[annotation]*.
- **Vacant, demolished or rebuilt.** Leaving structures vacant lowers nearby values by up to 4.1%, while demolition followed by full reconstruction raises them by up to 14.1%. Negative spillovers concentrate in low- and middle-income tracts (vom Hofe et al., 2018).
- **Business Improvement Districts in New York City.** These raised property values inside their boundaries, with no significant spillover outside (Ellen et al., 2007) *[annotation]*.
- **The Main Street Program.** A causal test of the program, a difference-in-differences design across four Midwestern states, found no significant pooled effect on downtown jobs or establishments, with large differences between states (Van Leuven, 2022). A companion study finds higher home prices in participating communities, especially near the downtown (Van Leuven, 2024). The program may work more as a residential amenity than as a retail engine.

5.3 The commercial evidence gap

Nearly every estimate above concerns *residential* property. A cost study for Pittsburgh explicitly excluded spillovers from vacant commercial buildings "because there are no reliable studies available to generate such estimates." It notes that these costs are likely significant (Immergluck et al., 2017). The same study puts the lost tax from a vacant commercial property at about $2,300 a year, against $584 for a residential one *[annotation]*.

We found no rigorous study that isolates what a vacant storefront does to nearby values. Nor did we find any Baltimore estimate of the *gain* from bringing a vacant commercial building back into use. Every local figure measures the penalty of vacancy, not the payoff from fixing it.

Policy is also thin. Baltimore does not track long-term empty storefronts, while Washington, D.C. requires vacant buildings to be registered within 90 days (Gellman & Jayaraman, 2026).

5.4 Viability of reuse

Survey evidence suggests owners regard adaptive reuse of commercial buildings as a viable alternative to demolition (Bullen, 2007). But the binding constraint on Greenmount appears to be the gap between rehabilitation cost and achievable rent. In local reporting, corridor property owners describe renovation costs that exceed what a commercial space can earn by sale or lease, along with sharply higher insurance costs and difficulty raising capital (Gellman & Jayaraman, 2026).

One local counter-example shows how the gap can close. Red Emma's, a worker cooperative, spent about $1.6 million to buy and renovate two buildings at 3128 Greenmount with help from the Central Baltimore Partnership (Gellman & Jayaraman, 2026).

Studies of the returns to Maryland and Baltimore City historic tax credits were identified (Abell Foundation, 2020; PlaceEconomics, 2020) but not yet reviewed. They belong in the final review because tax credits are a main lever for closing the cost gap.

6. Precedent: Programming Greenmount Before (RQ4)

Government has tried to plan this street at least three times. The National Register nomination documents Waverly's commercial history in detail:

- **1878:** 38 businesses, including four saloons.
- **About 1900:** nineteen saloons.
- **1934:** a new Waverly Market at Greenmount and 33rd Street.
- **1983:** more than 70 merchants.

The nomination also records long-lived businesses such as Pete's Grill and Hack's Shoe Repair. It credits Memorial Stadium with the street's post-war heyday; local reporting traces the corridor's recent struggles to the stadium's closure in the 1990s (Gellman & Jayaraman, 2026).

1940: the Waverly study. *Waverly: A Study in Neighborhood Conservation* was one of the country's first neighborhood conservation efforts. Its approach, later renamed the "Baltimore Plan", was used across the city and borrowed by housing officials nationally. It was followed by a late-1940s slum-clearance project of 22 acres. The nomination records that this project "create[d] pockets of poverty and cut off existing social networks" (Maryland Historical Trust, 2013).

1975–1984: the Commercial Revitalization Program. The City's files, indexed by the team (31 folders, 1,692 pages), show what this program did:

- **The deal.** The City built the streetscape, the 33rd Street median and a municipal parking lot, roughly $1.1 million in public works. Owners had to bring their facades into line with adopted design standards, at their own expense.
- **Help for owners.** Owners were offered free design help and 7% City loans. The captions show no facade grants.
- **Legal footing.** The standards were adopted in the Waverly Business Area Urban Renewal Plan, Council Bill 2278 of 1979.

The renewal plan, as amended, remains in force. According to the team's reading, it has prohibited new taverns, liquor stores and pawnshops since 1995 *[team reading, to be confirmed with the Department of Planning]*.

Two lessons follow. First, design-led programs paid for by merchants did not stop the high turnover the nomination describes. Second, a heritage-anchored recommendation can collide with current rules. Food and drink is the frontage's most-documented historic trade, and the team's extractor finds a span coded as a bar or tavern on 13 parcels. Yet new taverns are barred. Our method must therefore flag uses that are "proven but not permitted."

7. Synthesis: Gaps and Implications for Our Method

Read together, the literature gives us tools but not answers. The heritage evidence says history has value, but in sizes that depend on the regime and the market, and almost entirely for housing. The retail evidence says the mix and the foot traffic matter more than any single building. The Baltimore evidence

measures what vacancy costs, not what reuse earns. Table 2 summarizes the gaps and how the project responds.

Table 2. Gaps in the literature and how the project responds

Gap	Why it matters here	How our method responds
No study tests whether a building's *former use* predicts the success of a new use	This is the core assumption of the heritage anchor	Treat history as a prior, not an effect size. Write an explicit anchor rule. Back-test it on parcels whose later uses are known. Report the result as a finding.
Heritage-value evidence is mostly residential and mostly from local regimes	Waverly is commercial and National Register-listed; its design rules come from an urban renewal plan, not a landmark law	Do not transfer headline premiums. Cite ranges with their regime and market. Weight comps from National Register commercial districts.
No rigorous estimate of spillovers from vacant *commercial* buildings	Vacancy on Greenmount is mostly commercial	State this limit openly. Use residential estimates only as a lower-bound reference, labeled as such.
No Baltimore estimate of the gain from reuse	The sponsor needs the upside, not only the penalty	Build the upside from operating comps and achievable rent. Calibrate against the sponsor's NDA restaurant data without publishing it.
No agreed definition of saturation for neighborhood corridors	The tenant-mix module depends on it	Define saturation from Huff-type market areas, tenant-mix diversity and footfall. Run sensitivity checks on the threshold.
Effects are reported in non-comparable units (per property, yes/no, log points)	Side-by-side comparisons can mislead	Report each effect in its own units, convert log points explicitly, and never pool them in one chart.
Designation and revitalization can raise status and displace incumbents	Long-standing businesses and residents are part of the street's value	Add a "who stays" check to recommendations and flag existing tenants at risk.

Where the project later estimates the effect of an intervention with staggered timing, recent difference-in-differences estimators (Callaway & Sant'Anna, 2021; Sun & Abraham, 2021) are the appropriate methods.

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Appendix A. Depth of Reading by Source

"Full text" means the document was read directly. "Abstract" means the published abstract was read; findings beyond the abstract come from a cited secondary source. "Annotation" means the figure comes only from the sponsor's reading list or proposal and must be verified.

Source	Route	Read as	Note
Been et al. (2016) / NBER WP 20446	Sponsor list	Full text	Effect sizes from the working paper
Manganelli et al. (2023)	Sponsor list	Full text	Source of figures for Coulson & Leichenko, Leichenko et al., Narwold et al., Asabere et al.
Steinberg (2011)	Sponsor list	Full text (intro, conclusion)	
NR nominations: Waverly Main Street, St. John's, Charles Village/Abell	Sponsor list	Full text (significance sections)	OCR text; check figures against page images
Gellman & Jayaraman (2026), *The Baltimore Banner*	Sponsor list	Full text	Context only
Immergluck et al. (2017)	Sponsor list	Full text (searched)	Commercial cost per year from annotation
Ahlfeldt & Maennig (2010); Han (2014); McCabe & Ellen (2016); Rossi-Hansberg et al. (2010); Van Leuven (2022)	Sponsor list	Abstract	Han's −0.9% per property from annotation
Coulson & Leichenko (2001); Narwold et al. (2008); Asabere et al. (1994)	Sponsor list / citation chasing	Via Manganelli et al.	Full text needed
Patrick (2025); Ganduri & Maturana (2024); Ellen et al. (2007); BNIA-JFI (2016); Miller & McComas (2022)	Sponsor list	Annotation (+ press summaries for Miller & McComas)	Verify all figures; Patrick's article number is 104157 per DOI, not 104074 as in the July proposal
Rosen (1974); Huff (1964); Jacobs (1961); Brown (2021); Callaway & Sant'Anna (2021); Sun & Abraham (2021)	Sponsor list	Standard references	Cited for their well-known core arguments
Leichenko et al. (2001); Coulson & Lahr (2005); Noonan & Krupka (2011); Waights (2018); Oba & Noonan (2020); Zhou (2020)	Search Q1	Abstract	
Arentze et al. (2005); Gerbich (1998); Song et al. (2023)	Search Q2	Abstract	
Van Leuven (2024); Bullen (2007); vom Hofe et al. (2018); Han (2019)	Searches Q3–Q5	Abstract	
Koster & Rouwendal (2017); Ahlfeldt et al. (2017); Koster et al. (2019); Meltzer & Schuetz (2012); Meltzer & Capperis (2017); Pashigian & Gould (1998); Brueckner (1993)	Citation chasing	Abstract (Brueckner: title and secondary description)	

Team precedent memo (2026)	Primary/local	Full text	Built from archive captions; scans not yet read by eye

Appendix B. AI-Use Statement

Following the course syllabus, we disclose that this draft was prepared with the assistance of Claude (Anthropic) on October 21, 2026. Claude was used to:

- run and log the OpenAlex searches;
- extract text from the sponsor's PDFs;
- draft the prose and tables.